Mythical Thoughts and Ideological Borders in Chinua Achebe's *Arrow of God*

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Abstract
Myths pertain to historicized narratives, ideas, and beliefs that have become institutionalized in a society and made part of their discourses. Mythological ideas get into the discourses of people once they become widespread in society, and they are usually communicated through the mass media and literary texts. One of such is Chinua Achebe's *Arrow of God*. Review of previous studies indicates that scholarly papers on the novel are not lacking in existing literature. However, the review revealed that only a few scholarly papers have studied cultural myths in the novel from the critical discourse perspective, which is the gap that this paper has sought to close. Therefore, the paper examines mythical thoughts and ideological borders in *Arrow of God,* and objectified to identify and discuss the ideological basis of the myths in the novel, and then show how the cultural myths create territories and borders in Umuaro clan. The paper adopts Norman Fairclough's model of critical discourse analytical framework where he defines ideology as common sense assumptions and expectations which are taken for granted. The study collected mythical corpuses from the primary text which formed the basis for the analysis and discussions. Results obtained from the study identifies, among others, Ulu, Ezeulu, Idemili, Ikenga, and the Python as cultural myths in the novel. It also links beliefs in them to common sense assumptions, and concluded that, though the activities associated with the myths are rallying points for the people, they nevertheless created ideological territories and borders in the novel.
Keywords: Myth, thought, ideology, border, Chinua Achebe, Arrow of God

Introduction
The various ways by which human beings become aware of something is treated under the broader philosophical field of epistemology. One of such ways is intuition, the ability of humans to discern knowledge on their own. There is a philosophical belief that the power of knowing is internal to mankind because they have been naturally endowed with knowledge. Understanding has also been traced to a divine source. Religious adherents believe that the aetiology of all wisdom and knowledge is God himself; since he is supposed to be all knowing, those who worship God are believed to obtain special revelations from him. Similarly, cognitive philosophers talk about the experiential basis of knowledge to suggest that most of the things that people know or are aware of, come from interactions with the world (Lakoff & Johnson, 1980).

In addition to the above sources of knowledge is mythology. Myths originate from the desire to know or have information on a phenomenon. They are historical constructions, tales, and beliefs that are widely accepted and lived out in many

societies, and they pertain to what people do when there are no better ways to explain a problem or situation. Consequently, science, history, anthropology, linguistics and religion have been found to have depended on one type of mythology or another to explain away many things. The "Big Bang" theory is gaining attention today due to the inability of science to offer an acceptable account of how the universe was created. Migration stories contain a lot of myths with tales of extra-ordinary happenings during the movement. Mythology has been used as well to account for the origin of language. In Hinduism, language is said to have originated from the goddess "Sarasvati", the wife of "Brahma" and creator of the universe (Yule, 1997, p. 1). Even theologians believe that the creation narratives in the Holy Bible are part of the mythology of the Jews, and according to an Egyptian mythology, the Hermopolitan and Heliopolitan systems are believed to be opposite partners in the creation process. The two, as this mythology states, are made to lie together in order to procreate (Onyewuenyi, 1994).

Apart from the epistemological function, myths give people and their society a sense of distinctness. People are identified by the myths about them. Hence, mankind often times fall back on mythology not just as a way to close an existing gap of knowledge, but more also to give themselves uniqueness. The idea is that certain things have to be explained; otherwise, there will a crisis of recognition. So, they are thrown up so as not to live anyone in doubt. Therefore, myths are lived out as practices by people in their day-to-day activities and they form the basis of most cultural beliefs.

There is a connection between mythical thoughts and literature. Barthes (1972) notes that everything has the potential to become a myth once it changes to an oral or open state. As people continue to talk about a thing and refer to it frequently, that thing becomes conventional among the people and begins to appear in all their discourses. According to Stivale (2002), discourses, whether oral or textual, are usually spread by mass communications such as newspapers, cinema, theatre, and so forth.

Imaginative literature is also one the means through which mythical ideas are spread. Many cultural practices, once they have gained much popularity, also become textualised in literature. Hence, in many literary texts are a lot of mythologies. This means that myths need to be studied in literature in order to interrogate the extent of their "culturalness", and see how they affect the people who believe in them. It is the desire to understand all of these that our paper examines mythical thoughts and ideological borders in Chinua Achebe's *Arrow of God*.

Literature Review

Myth and ideology are very useful concepts in this paper. Myths, whether viewed from anthropological, structural and semiotic perspectives, say something about a people and certain aspects of their thought processes for which they are known. Barthes (1972, p.124) sees myth as belonging to semiology since it is simultaneously a "signifier" and a "signified". He describes it as the transformation of language from its object or pristine form to another level of language which he so-calls "meta-language", and refers to it as "innocent speech", since readers consume myth innocently, and believe as well that they are statements of facts. Tao (2013) interprets myths from Barthes' perspective as meaning not epics and stories as held traditionally, but as language or a

form of communication which makes less transparent the historicisation and politicization of the "quotidian" by making them look normal. Bazzul (2015), in a similar manner, hints that myths function by altering and limiting the complexities of history for underlying ideological or cultural reasons and explains that the power of myths is not in what they hide, but in their ability to make daily events look normal, natural and innocent. Myths is normally traced to a distant source which is often quoted and referred to, so that in the end, a long tradition of 'someone said' is institutionalized and accepted as authentic by the people.

The term "ideology", since inception, has been used in different ways. Freeden (2003, p. 7-9) explains that ideology, at the time of the French Enlightenment, was defined as "false consciousness", because it was seen as ideas that were promoted to turn things and situations upside down, in a 'camera obscura' fashion. Marx (1932) understands ideology as "alienation", which he defines as a situation which involves the worker losing the object of his product. According to him, alienation happens in different ways, one of which is to widen the social gap between labour and capital, but in *The German Ideology,* Marx and Friedrich Engels (1846) no longer see ideology as alienation, but as a sublimation of the economic production processes, which consists in the crafting of economic and philosophical terms and propositions that produced in the people a form of 'social consciousness' bound up with 'social practices that tinkered with people's consciousness. In linguistic studies, ideologies are conceptualised as discourse. To Fairclough (1989), ideology is primarily discursive because it is exercised in discourse. As discourse, it is more of "who is saying what to whom for what purposes" (Eagleton, 1991, p. 9); in other words, it is discourse to the extent that it is all about the actual use of language between particular human subjects for the production of specific effects, and also marks the points where power is brought to bear on certain utterances and makes itself part of them.

Many research investigations have been carried out on Chinua Achebe's *Arrow of God*. Mullen (1989) studied Ezeulu's masculinity in *Arrow of God* albeit his position as chief priest and pointed out that he used the priestly office to show his manliness. He concluded that his desire to demonstrate his masculine strength was undermined by his lust for power and his anxiety about losing his position which are seen as challenging his status. Parks (1999) investigated the relationship between violence, gender and the problem of masculinity and pointed out that violence is used by Ezeulu in *Arrow of God* to assert his masculinity which alienated him from his community and made him unable to fulfill his roles effectively.

Wright (2011) used the character of Ezeulu to discuss the poetics of myth in *Arrow of God* to explore the tension between individual and communal identities in a rapidly changing society and suggests that Ezeulu is caught between the cultural values of his Igbo society and the modernity brought by the colonial authorities; he concluded that Ezeulu's dilemma represents the dilemma that faced the Igbo race in the face of colonialism. Okafor (2012) used *osu* and the oracle to study resistance and accommodation in *Arrow of God* and argued that Ezeulu's resistance is shaped by his own personal motivations and his inability to reconcile them with those of the stronger colonial forces which leads him to his tragedy

Odiambo (2014) focused on a post-colonial reading of *Arrow of God* with emphasis on the effects of colonialism on a traditional African society and suggested that Ezeulu's struggle to maintain his authority is also symbolic of the struggle between traditional African society and the British colonial system. Turner (2014) did a paper on Ezeulu and the persistence of tradition and argued that, despite the changes brought about by colonialism in the novel, the characters are still able to preserve the traditional Igbo culture; he submitted that, though Ezeulu ultimately failed in his struggle against colonialism, he nevertheless stands for resistance through his strong attachment to the culture.

Mehta (2016) explored Achebe's critique of the colonial project in the novel and concluded that Ezeulu, Nwaka, and the white District Commissioner represent different perspectives with regard to the colonial project. Babatunde (2020) examined anti-colonial reading of Acebe's *Arrow of God* and sets down the novel as basically a critique of colonialism and its destructive effects on Igbo culture. He sees the novel as challenging cultural superiority and a window to an alternative future that is based on justice and equality.

Previous studies are related to the present article in a few ways. Firstly, the object of study of both of them is *Arrow of God*. A few of the previous studies also touched on the thematic field of myth and cultural practices, which is what our paper is looking at. However, most of the papers in extant literature engaged mainly with issues bothering on masculinity, resistance and accommodation, and cultural dominance and their effects. Our paper goes beyond these issues to look at the ideologies underlying the myths in the novel and their effects on Umuaro society from the critical discourse perspective. It is based on these differences that the present study seeks to close the gaps of knowledge. Hence, this paper objectifies to identify and discuss the ideological basis of the myths in the novel, and show how the cultural myths create territories and borders in the text.

Analytical Framework

Analysis and discussion of our corpuses in this article are based on the framework of critical discourse. Critical linguistics, according to Fowler (1991), is the study of the minute details of linguistic structure against the backdrop of social and historical situations in order to expose the systems of beliefs and values which are usually encoded in language. For Van Dijk (1993; 2001), CDA engages with the various ways by which social power abuse, dominance and inequality are enacted, reproduced and resisted by text and talk in the social and political context. The field, from the point of view of Charteris-Black (2004), is concerned with increasing people's awareness of the social relations that are forged, maintained and reinforced by language use in order to change them.

Our analytical framework is Norman Fairclough's (1989) meaning of ideology as "common sense". Common sense, according to him, was first used by Harold Garfinkel in one of his titles "The familiar common-sense world of everyday life" which he used to explain the world as built mainly on assumptions and expectations that regulate the actions of people in their societies, and which they also use to interpret

the actions of others. Fairclough posits that ideologies occur in discourses as assumptions and expectations which are taken for granted on account of their seemingly reasonableness or sensibleness. Hence, he hinges the effectiveness of all ideologies on their ability to shroud thoughts or ideas, and other forms of social actions with a common-sense background, since cultural issues are sold and bought on the merit of their links with reasonableness. Shedding more light on this, Eagleton (1991, p. 51) points out that ideologies exist because of the belief that people must not think or say anything about certain things, especially those things that offer themselves as "Of course", or "That goes without saying".

A characteristic of the common-sense ideology, according to Fairclough (1989, p.85-86), is its invisible nature. He stresses that invisibility is achieved when ideologies are brought into discourse not as explicit elements of the text, stating that ideology is much more effective when its workings are least visible; in other words, the assumptions and expectations are always not obvious or made very clear, and as a result, people are not consciously aware of them. Therefore, he describes them as "the background assumptions which lead the text producer to textualise the world in a particular way". This, in his opinion, is also the reason why people do not examine or question such assumptions.

Ideological common sense is also described by Fairclough (1989) in terms of naturalized conversations. He explains that ideological common sense owes its identity to the naturalization of the discourse type which embodies them, and clarifies that once an ideology has been naturalized, it is shared by virtually all members of an institution or a society and then used to establish and consolidate solidarity relations among members of the social group. According to Fowler (1991, p. 57), naturalization of conversation implies "a commonly held view of the world, a shared objective reality that is taken for granted and does not have to be proved". Similarly, Eagleton (1991, p. 59) explains naturalization as a situation whereby ideology freezes itself into a "second nature", presenting it as spontaneous, inevitable and so unalterable"

Systems of ideas are said to vary among members of an institution or a society. Ideological variation is explained by Fairclough (1989) in terms of its diversity. Therefore, he notes that discourse types are ideologically particular and ideologically variable, which means that in many instances, ideological uniformity is only partially achieved. In short, he maintains that diversity of thought often produces counter or oppositional ideologies which often leads to conflict and struggle between the people who hold different ideas. It is in view of the diverse nature of ideology that Eagleton (1991, p. 101) characterizes the ideological realm as one of contestations and negotiation dominated by "a constant busy traffic", where meanings and values are stolen, transformed, appropriated across the frontiers of different classes and groups, surrendered, repossessed and reinflected.

Ideology, from the point of view of Fairclough (1989), is essentially tied to relations of power. As a matter of fact, he emphasises that ideological common sense is only commonsensical in the service of sustaining asymmetrical relations of power. He states that those who hold power are constantly striving to impose an ideological common sense that is shared by everyone; hence, what comes to be ideological

common sense is determined by those who exercise power and domination in a society. According to him, the stake is usually about who establishes or maintains one type of discourse as the dominant one in a given social domain, and by extension, who establishes or maintains certain ideological common sense.

Many cultural practices are mythical and commonsensical, with the consequence that they are usually taken for granted. It is these taken-for-granted cultural practices in Achebe's *Arrow of God* that this article is trying to explore, and this is what makes the framework and the adopted models very relevant to the paper.

Methods

This study employs the qualitative-descriptive research design to investigate mythical thoughts and ideological borders in Chinua Achebe's *Arrow of God*. Data on the myths is based on the corpuses generated from the primary text while discussion of the data adopts Norman Fairclough's view of ideology as common sense.

Myths and Common-Sense Practices in Chinua Achebe's *Arrow of God*

Myths are narratives that embody the culture, religious beliefs and social values of a group. Mythical events and processes are historical, and they originate from timeless memory. The purpose for which they are introduced in discourses is for them to be sustained in the world-view of the people. One can say without equivocation that the entire plot of Chinua Achebe's *Arrow of God* is woven around mythical ideas. In other words, the novel is an archetypal narrative which relies on the creation of myths and symbols to understand a people and their world, as well as structure their self-image. All the actions in the novel are either reactions or responses to one mythical belief or another, and bound up with assumptions and practices that are commonsensical in nature.

Myths are used to explain natural phenomenon or occurrences, such as origin or tales about people and places. As one learns from Ezeulu in the earliest part of the novel, the founding of Umuaro and Okperi are mythical: "My father said this to me that when our village first came here to live the land belonged to Okperi" (p. 15). However, this claim is counteracted in an alternative perspective as told by Nwaka:

> Ezeulu has told us what his father told him about the olden days.... But we also know that the lore of the land is beyond the knowledge of many fathers.... He speaks about events which are older than Umuaro itself... My father told me a different story... (p. 16).

Cultural myths are sustained by ideological practices, and ideologies are assumptions and practices that are commonsensical in nature. According to Fairclough (1989), ideological common-sense appeals to the reasonableness of an idea. He notes that they are the assumptions and expectations which are normal and given, and they control the actions of members of the society. Hence, notwithstanding the contrasting perspectives about the founding myth in the novel, it is not for Umuaro to subject these views to further interrogations. Both of them are accepted as matters of fact and taken

for granted. Their acceptance could be seen in the way they have been used to control and shape the people's attitude or behaviour about the war. In addition, Ezeulu is appealing to the common sense that going to war with Okperi would be a moral fallacy while Nwaka suggests that whatever happened in the past is inconsequential now and submits that it is only reasonable and commonsensical for Umuaro to put the past behind them and face the present reality.

Mythologies are usually the basis for which religious, spiritual and ceremonial practices are enacted, explained or justified. The narratives about Ulu are mythical and historical. According to the myth, the deity is the god of 'mother earth' and superintends over other deities in the clan. Ulu is feared and revered throughout Umuaro; some descriptive phrases used for the deity are, the god that humbles a man 'when his life is sweetest to him' (p. 27), and, "great Ulu that kills and saves ..." Ezeulu believes that Ulu is the real deity of Umuaro and the history is still at his finger tips:

> Things were so bad for the six villages that their leaders came together to save themselves. They hired a strong team of medicine-men to install a common deity for them. This deity which the fathers of the six villages made was called Ulu.... The six villages took the name of Umuaro and the priest of Ulu became their chief priest. From that day they were never again beaten by an enemy (p. 15).

Fairclough (1989) notes that the effectiveness of any ideology depends largely on the extent to which it can merge with the common-sense background to the discourse. Thus, to Ezeulu, Ulu is incorruptible, and there are many others in Umuaro who rely on background expectations and assumptions about Ulu's power to purify households of defilements. Umuaro assumes that the deity is fundamental to their existence as a people; hence, obedience to the god, his precepts, ordinances, and participation in practices associated with it are only a matter of common sense which is also taken for granted. Even Ezeulu's greatest critic, Nwaka, would refer to Ulu as "the great deity of Umuaro". Therefore, it is in the consciousness of Umuaro that Ulu is the reason for the continuous existence and safety.

However, Ulu is not the only deity that is revered in the novel. Idemili is also historicized as a myth in Umuaro with many common-sense assumptions about it. According to Barthes (1972), often times, myths are consumed innocently because readers see them as inductive statements. Among the Umuaro people, Idemili is held as a 'great deity' in the clan, and perhaps second to Ulu. The deity is celebrated annually in Umunneora village by the representation of the Ogalanya mask which is supposed to speak for it. Its priest, Ezeidemili furnishes readers with more information on the deity:

> Every boy in Umuaro knows that Ulu was made by our fathers long ago. But Idemili was there at the beginning of things. Nobody made it.... Idemili means pillar of water. As the pillar of this house holds the roof so does

> Idemili hold up the rain cloud in the sky so that it does not fall down.... Idemili belongs to the sky (p. 41-42).

Mythical process, according to Barthes (1972), involves a process that makes history look less transparent. For instance, in this culture, Idemili is believed to live in the sky and controls rainfall. Therefore, offences against the god are believed to be punishable with cessation of rainfall unless adequately propitiated. Other ideological practices associated with this deity are worship and reverence of the royal python. The culture forbids anyone from doing anything that harms it; hence, Ezeulu, Akuebue, Anosi and Matefi are unanimous in their condemnation of Uduche for mistreating the python which attest to the gravity of the desecration. Indeed, the novel describes the deity as "the personal deity of Umunneora".

A major characterising feature of myths is the presence of archetypal characters in the narrative. An archetypal character occupies a representative position and normally performs fundamental duties that are widely acknowledged and accepted by audiences. Ezeulu also represents an archetypal mythical character in the novel by virtue of his position as the chief priest of Ulu deity. According to the myth, an "Ezeulu" is appointed to minister to the deity from time to time, so that there has always been an Ezeulu since the institution of the deity from time immemorial. From generations to generations, an Ezeulu is regarded as the earthly representative of this deity because it is assumed that Ulu's power also rubs off on his appointed priest. As a result, the priest is perceived by Umuaro as both human and divine, and honored as such. The people see the god in the person of Ezeulu as a result of which he claims a superhuman identity, and this is very well attested to in the text in his conversations with Akuebue:

> I can see things where other men are blind. That is why I am known and at the same time I am unknowable.... You are my friend...but you cannot know the thing which beats the drum to which Ezeulu dances (p. 132).

In Umuaro cosmology, this self-immolation by Ezeulu is commonsensical, with the consequence that whatever he says or does is taken for granted, and this is what also informs Akuebue's reply: "I am your friend and I can talk to you as I like; but this does not mean I forget that half of you is man and the other half spirit" (133). Not only Akuebue but also many other characters in Umuaro hold this type of opinion about Ezeulu. Therefore, in this culture, Ezeulu is mystified as someone else, and the reason, according to Barthes (1972), is that consumers of myth do not see it as a semiotic process but as statements of facts. It is for the same reason that Obiageli does not need to relish his father's roasted yam because the culture makes her aware that no other person eats a bit of that yam except Ezeulu. Barthes (1972) categorizes myth into two levels of meaning: meaning at the level of language object, and meaning at the level of metalanguage. Therefore, the ordinary character that the people know as Ezeulu is transformed to another person in the metalanguage which is also the myth, and this is the culturally shared opinion of the man. Since the myths are situated in the culture, whatever there are about them are supposed to be in public knowledge and therefore

requires no interrogation; they are the 'of course' or 'everybody knows' of social practices. It is therefore worth stating that Ezeulu's popularity, power and respect, all derive from the people's belief in his connection with Ulu.

Even Ezeulu's audacious posturing in the midst of the New Yam controversy is not unconnected with this kind of taken-for-granted self-abasement of the people. He is simply inspired by the people's ideological legitimation of age-long practices associated with the festival:

> I need not speak in riddles. You all know what our custom is. I only call a new festival when there is only one yam left from the last. Today I have three yams and so I know that the time has not come (p. 207).

Although Nnanyelugo and Udeozo know that the extension is due to his absence from Umuaro, they are at a loss as to what to say, with Nnanyelugo forced to admit: "We all know the custom and no one can say that Ezeulu has offended against it", a position also assumed by Udeozo: "Ezeulu…we know that such a thing has never been done before" (207). Even the much younger Obika would liken their persuasive effort as amounting to urging the priest of Ulu "to put his head in a cooking pot' (p. 212). The two elders are just speechless since the people have tacitly consented to the practice that has been manufactured by the culture. Of course, they have the ideological awareness that doing anything to the contrary would violate the long-established tradition which has its basis on the myth, even though the situation has now become very hurting to Umuaro. This is why Fairclough (1989) describes an ideological situation as "institutional practices which people draw upon without thinking', and which Eagleton (1991) also describes as a matter of 'freeing ourselves from ourselves".

Mythical ideas are often times used as foundations for understanding the world, always combining history with fantasy. Barthes (1972) also hints that a tightly closed or silent object has the potential to become a myth, especially if it changes to an oral or open state and begins to appear in the discourses of people. This means that myth is a speech that has already been worked on and made suitable for use in communication. According to Stivale (2002), communications about myth are normally spread by different media such as newspapers, cinemas, theatre and other creative outlets. The novel describes Ikenga as "the very life of a person" and this mythical object is kept by the head of a household to symbolize the presence of his ancestors in his household. The common sense associated with Ikenga is so strong that only a stupid person could risk underrating it. Thus, among the people, it is common knowledge that anyone without the mythical object is, in the real sense of it, "defenceless". The war between Umuaro and Okperi is a direct consequence of the meta-communications about Ikenga in the culture of Umuaro and neigbhouring clans, albeit the failure of someone to act responsibly in a matter that touches on the very existence of a person. Therefore, it is an existential threat for anyone to have had his Ikenga broken by another, which was what Akukalia did exactly to Ebo. Umuaro, though angered by the murder of one of their own, does not hesitate in condemning Akukalia's act, despite the cold relationship between them and Okperi:

> Let us put ourselves in the place of the man he had made a corpse before his eyes', they said. 'Who would bear such a thing? What propitiation or sacrifice would atone for such sacrilege? How would the victim set out putting himself right again with his fathers unless he could say to them: Rest, for the man that did it has paid with his head? Nothing short of that would have been adequate (p. 25).

Therefore, it is clear from the above conversations that knowledge of Ikenga is prosaic in this culture. All are in the awareness that Akukalia committed an abomination unheard of, and that a man who does this to his neigbhour creates enmity between him and his ancestors; they do not mince words in saying that Akukalia committed an unforgivable offence and that Ebo had been badly provoked indeed. Therefore, they make it clear that their choice of war is not for the fact that one of theirs has been murdered, but for Okperi's refusal to report the incident, which to them, amounts to impunity.

In a nutshell, therefore, Ulu, Ezeulu, the New Yam, Idemili, the Python, and Ikenga are mythical referents in the novel. Moreover, their popularity and the mysteries associated with them owe largely to the common-sense assumptions about them which are deep rooted in the culture of the people, and most of the times, taken for granted.

Territories and Borders in *Arrow of God*

Mythical ideas are normally regarded as fundamental to a people's existence, which is why they would be stoutly defended whenever perceived to be threatened or violated. The prevalence of cultural myths in *Arrow of God* may be said to have contributed, in many ways, to build and sustain communal peace and harmony across Umuaro. At various times, the cultural practices associated with each myth have indeed served as rallying points for the people of the clan. However, at other times, they have also tended to divide rather than unite Umuaro. Thus, the myths in the novel may also be described as "territories" with marked "borders". We situate this claim in line with Fairclough (1989, p. 101), who avers that ideas are "a realm of contestation and negotiation, in which there is a constant busy traffic".

The borders in the text are products of the ideas in contention, where the contending parties are speaking from distinct territories. In the discourses on the founding myth, Ezeulu and Nwaka may be likened to two ideological territories with a marked border. According to Barthes (1972), those who promote myth appeal to feelings and prejudices, and in this instance, the founding of the two clans is not only historicized but also politicized by Ezeulu and Nwaka who represent two perspectives of the myth, and so two territories. The perspectives presented by them succeed in dividing Umuaro along two lines where each mythical school is maintaining its own side of the border. The polarity is later to determine whether or not Umuaro would choose peace or war with Okperi.

Ideas, according to Fairclough (1989), are never uniform, with the consequence that conflict and struggle often emerge between the disputants. Ulu and Idemili are

supposed to have been instituted for the interest of Umuaro clan. Although the people of Umuaro hold Ulu and Idemili deities in high esteem, there is mutual antagonism between the deities and their priests. The priests are locked in ideological tussle which also rubs off on their respective worshippers. Ezeulu is the least surprised about this, because as much as he knows,

> the priest of Idemili and ogwugwu and Eru and Udo had never been happy with their secondary role since the villages got together and made Ulu and put him over the other deities (40).

Common sense is bound up with power, and since it is tied to power relations, those who have power always try to impose an ideological commonsense (Fairclough, 1989). In the scenario, Ezeulu is doing all in his power to re-assert that superiority; hence, he concludes that anyone trying to dispute the superiority of Ulu is only expressing a natural grudge which is expected though, especially from rival deities and their priests. Thus, in discourse, people who hold power at a particular moment have to constantly reassert their power. Ezeulu is not the only one who is acting out his power but Ezidemili as well, as he counters:

> My father did not tell me that before Umuaro went to war it took leave from the priest of Ulu....Let us not listen to anyone trying to frighten us with the name of Ulu...And we have all heard how the people of Aninta dealt with the deity when he failed them....Did they not carry him to the boundary between them and their neigbhours and set it on fire? (p. 28).

Ezidemili and Nwaka urge the people not to be afraid of a god that they made. Thus, there is a raging "cold war" between worshippers of the two deities. Therefore, there are imaginary territories and borders between the two groups resulting from the antagonism between their earthly priests. The discourses show that they are not in agreement with one another as to which of the gods deserves more respect.

As may be recalled in the myth, Ulu and Idemili are rival deities in Umuaro; each deity has its own areas of jurisdiction with clearly marked boundaries between them. The rivalries extend to other practices associated with them. To use the royal Python as a case, this snake is revered very much in Umuaro; it could crawl over people's roof-tops without anyone daring to harm it because of some ideologically naturalised assumptions associated with it which are taken for granted. It is under the exclusive jurisdiction of Idemili and his priest, and infractions against it are normally sanctioned appropriately. This is also why the mistreatment of the Python by Oduche is viewed not only as a sacrilege, but also a jurisdictional breach. The resulting condemnations of Oduche across the clan by most people, including his father, are an admittance that Oduche has indeed strayed out of his "zone" of influence, an act perceived by Ezidemili as unwarranted "border incursion". Ideological meanings and values, Fairclough (1989) argues, may be surrendered and repossessed as well. Ezidemili is not prepared to surrender the meanings and values attached to the Python.

Hence, he wastes no time in lodging his protest to Ezeulu: "Ezidemili wants to know what you are going to do about the abomination which has been committed in your house…." But the alleged aggressor is intransigent and refuses to be apologetic: "Go back and tell Ezidemili to eat shit…." (p. 54). Thus, Ezeulu violates religious boundaries with impunity and does not appear to want to promote cross-border faith co-existence. On the other hand, Ezidemili is seen taking steps to repossess the meaning and values of the Python and thereby stop the "aggression".

Cultural discourses, Fairclough (1989) explains, are usually characterized by situations in which meanings and values are also stolen, transformed, appropriated across frontiers of different classes and groups. The physical, emotional, and ideological partitioning of Umuaro resulting from the New Yam festival lend some credence to the above assertion. What one sees in Umuaro represents attempts to either maintain the long-established tradition associated with the New Yam, or pull down the separating walls of the frontiers erected by culture. Therefore, in the text, there is a borderline between the conservatives and the iconoclasts. Thus, on one side of the border is Ezeulu with his followers who believe that going against the tradition is a risk not worth contemplating. To Ezeulu, Umuaro is only being punished by Ulu for turning their back on his priest during his detention and absence from home. Sometimes, he even imagines Ulu warning him against trying to intercede for people. Inspired by these thoughts, he is forthright in his reply:

> You have spoken well. But what you ask me to do is not done. Those yams are not food and a man does not eat them because he is hungry. You are asking me to eat death (207).

But those on the other side of the frontier are seeking to jettison the tradition. In the opinion of this school of thought, Ulu would not be happy to see a people he has been fostering suddenly come to ruin:

> Although I am not the priest of Ulu I can say that the deity does not want Umuaro to perish. We call him the saver. Therefore, you must find a way out, Ezeulu (207).

Against these trains of thought, Umuaro finds herself at a cross-road. The result is a heavy traffic of thought on the border, with Ezeulu struggling against the invading forces of the new thinkers who remain unwavering in the belief that Ulu was made for them and not the other way round. The situation becomes so interesting that some people are even threatening to deal with the god!

Interpersonal and inter-communal territories and borders are also enacted in the discourses on the myth of Ikenga in *Arrow of God*. In the first place, the sending of Akukalia as a diplomatic envoy involves the crossing of a physical border. Physically, Akukalia crosses from Umuaro to Okperi to broker a deal between the feuding clans. However, in the negotiation process, there is individulization of idea between Akukalia and Ebo. Acting on the strength of his ambassadorial role, Akukalia overstepped his

diplomatic bounds and crosses the red line when he encroaches on the personal boundary of Ebo and broke his Ikenga. He fails to recognize where his own boundary as an ambassador stops, and where that of another person begins. In diplomatic circles, Akukalia's act would be considered not worthy of his status as an ambassador. As a result, he loses his diplomatic immunity, and is declared a "persona non grata" in Okperi, which is acknowledged and backed by Umuaro:

> Let us put ourselves in the place of the man he had made a corpse before his eyes', they said. 'Who would bear such a thing? What propitiation or sacrifice would atone for such sacrilege? How would the victim set out putting himself right again with his fathers unless he could say to them: Rest, for the man that did it has paid with his head? Nothing short of that would have been adequate (p. 25).

In Umuaro, the worst a person can do to another is destroying what the culture regards as the very "life" of a person. Therefore, to Ebo, Akukalia's act is a clear invasion of his "individual" boundary; he has been pushed to the wall and pushed too hard and far. In his considered opinion, once an enemy pursues you and crosses into your individual territory, the only option left would be to fight back in defense, which is what he does exactly.

Therefore, it is safe to conclude that *Arrow of God* is full of boundaries at both the individual and communal level, such as between Umuaro and Okperi, Ulu and Idemili, Ezeulu and Ezidemili, and Ebo and Akukalia. The conflicts and frontiers have been brought about by the people's commonsensical assumptions or beliefs in their own cultural myths.

Conclusion

This research article investigated mythical thoughts and ideological borders in Chinua Achebe's *Arrow of God*. Review of related literature showed that previous studies on the novel had largely focused on masculinity, colonialism and cultural clashes. We went further in our paper to look at myths from the perspective of critical discourse analysis with the objectives, to identify and discuss the ideological basis of the myths in the novel, and show how the cultural myths create territories and borders in the text. The qualitative-descriptive research study adopted Norman Fairclough's (1989) perspective of ideology as common sense assumptions, practices and expectations about a belief. Data for the research were collected from the primary text. In the paper, we identified the founding of Umuaro and Okperi, the deities, Ezeulu, the Python, and Ikenga as mythical referents. We also showed that the importance attached to the myths in the novel owed largely to ideological assumptions about them, which are usually taken for granted. Finally, we pointed out that the social practices associated with the cultural myths created ideological territories and frontiers along the lines drawn by the myths and pitched the characters against one another.

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